Indians, wrote Megasthenes, are divided into seven castes. The first is *philosophers*, few in number but in ‘dignity preeminent over all’. Presumed ‘dear to the gods’, they conduct sacrifices and funeral rites for which ‘they receive valuable gifts and privileges’. He mentions two types of philosophers: ‘Brachmanes’ and ‘Sarmanes’—Brahmins and Sramanas (monks of Buddhist, Jain and other heterodox sects). The Brahmins guard their esoteric knowledge and do not communicate it even ‘to their wives, lest they should divulge any of the forbidden mysteries to the profane’. However, ‘women pursue philosophy with some of [the Sramanas]’.

The second caste is *farmers*, the most numerous of all. They’re seen as ‘public benefactors’ and no one harms them even during war. They live in the countryside and ‘pay a land-tribute to the king, because all India is the property of the crown, and no private person is permitted to own land’. They also ‘pay into the royal treasury a fourth part of the produce of the soil’. The third caste is *herders*, ‘who neither settle in towns nor in villages, but live in tents’ and by ‘hunting and trapping they clear the country of noxious birds and wild beasts’. The fourth caste is *artisans*, makers of weapons and tools for the herders and others. They’re ‘exempted from paying taxes’ and even get maintenance from the king. The fifth caste is *soldiers*, the second most numerous. They live ‘at the king’s expense’ and ‘when not engaged in active service, pass their time in idleness and drinking’. The sixth caste is *overseers*, tasked with administration and reporting anomalies to the magistrates. The seventh and the smallest caste is *councillors and assessors*, comprising wise people from whose ranks the king’s advisers, chief magistrates, state treasurers and army generals are drawn.

But this wasn’t some free-wheeling division of social labour. ‘No one is allowed to marry out of his own caste,’ writes Megasthenes, ‘or to exercise any calling or art except his own: for instance, a soldier cannot become a herder, or an artisan a philosopher.’ However, ‘An exception is made in favour of the philosopher, who for his virtue is allowed this privilege’, i.e., allowed to pursue other vocations and marry women from other castes—this could be how many Brahmins became councillors and assessors.[22]

What Megasthenes reports is the presence of endogamy based on occupation (the genesis of caste), though his divisions do not map on to the